Stop Being Average: Body, Money, Mind EP 338

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📋 Executive Summary

Brandon Carter delivers 25 lessons he wishes he knew at 25, organized across money, body, business, people, and mindset — rooted in losing his father to suicide, working 4 jobs during the 2008 recession, and eventually building multiple multi-figure businesses.

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🎙️ Intro, Sponsors & Hiring Announcement 0:55

- Episode 338 of Victory Talk Podcast, hosted by Brandon Carter ("Big Brandon Carter, King Keo, Gymnasium Jesus"), co-hosted live by DJ Cha Chaita Grande
- **Hiring setters** — commission-based remote sales role; no experience required
  - Setters call warm leads (no cold calling) and book them on sales calls with closers
  - Paid when the closer closes — setter gets commission without needing to close
  - Top performers can move up to closer; some of Brandon's closers have out-earned him in certain years
  - Apply via Typeform link in description (second link)
- **Sponsor: GoHighLevel** — the CRM Brandon's team uses for all leads, emails, and texts
  - 30-day free trial available via link in description
- **Sponsor: Brandon's own live training** — free class, Sunday October 18th at 7:00 PM EST
  - Topic: growing an online fitness business using AI
  - Brandon's AI content output in the last 30 days: 271 TikTok videos, 101 YouTube uploads (71 Shorts + 30 long-form), 92 Instagram Reels — with no human editors
  - Tools used: $500/month ChatGPT subscription + $200/month Claude subscription
  - Class covers: AI content editing, getting more clients, training clients with AI
  - Register even if you can't attend live — you'll be added to the email list
  - Strategic reason to start now: January is the highest-revenue month for online fitness; you want momentum built before the wave, not after it hits

📖 Brandon's Origin Story 1:150

- At age 24, just before his 25th birthday, Brandon's father took his own life
- Simultaneously, the 2008 Great Recession hit — Lehman Brothers collapsed, unemployment reached 10% (highest since the Depression)
- Brandon became the man of his family, needing to support his mother, sister, grandmother, and inherited debt from his father
- He couldn't find work despite having a college degree
- His daily grind for two years, 7 days a week:
  - Woke up at 4–5 AM to train personal training clients
  - Showered at the gym
  - Took the train from Harlem to Soho to work as a security guard at the Prada store for 8 hours
  - After that, worked for a friend's moving company
  - Weekends: trained clients in the morning, then managed a restaurant on Steinway Street in Queens
  - Total: 12–14 hour days, seven days a week for two years

- Eventually launched his first online training business — made his **first million** as an online trainer
- Has since taught over **15,000 people** how to build online fitness businesses; many make hundreds of thousands per year, some over $1M/year
- Now runs several multi-seven-figure businesses and one eight-figure business
- Currently 45 years old; has been in the fitness industry for 27 years

💰 Money Lesson 1: Sell Your Time Before You Try to Escape It 19:10

- Common advice — "don't exchange time for money" — is misapplied to most people
  - Most people aren't yet at the level where they need to worry about that
  - The fastest way to make money is to start by trading time for it
- Brandon's progression: gym trainer (2000, Bally's Total Fitness) → private clients at higher rates → online training (one of the first, 2009–2010)
  - Working in the gym taught him how to sell — which enabled him to eventually sell online training
  - Online training is selling *results*, not time — clients don't care how long it takes, just that they get the result
  - The iPhone launched in 2008; MyFitnessPal in 2009 — the infrastructure for online training didn't exist before that
- The real concept behind "don't trade time for money" is about **raising your hourly rate**
  - Warren Buffett still puts in time doing fundamental analysis on stocks — he just makes far more per hour than working in a gym
- How to calculate your hourly rate as an entrepreneur:
  - Track your work hours in your calendar (or ask Claude to count your work blocks)
  - Divide hours worked per week by money earned that week
  - Always be asking: how do I raise this number?
- Brandon notes: today, students with zero gym experience or certifications are doing **$50–100K/month** as online trainers

💰 Money Lesson 2: Work Hard Before Life Forces You To 26:15

- Brandon wishes he had gone much harder financially right out of college — or even during college
  - "There is an amount of money that if I had it, I'd still have a dad. I don't know what that number is."
  - Even if he couldn't have made that number, being in a stronger financial position would have made the family crisis easier to manage
- Instead, he was "messing around" in his 20s and got blindsided by emergency mode — 3–4 jobs, 12–14 hours/day for two years
- Key principles:
  - *"The more you sweat during peace, the less you bleed during war."*
  - *"Dig your well before you need it."*

    - Your life is not "an unbroken boulevard of bright lights from now until eternity" — your next tragedy is around the corner
    - When things are going well, go even harder — you don't know when it will stop
- Real example: a young successful guy Brandon knew in Miami
    - Was buying exotic cars, had a penthouse, very wealthy
    - Brandon warned him to stack money and prepare for things going wrong
    - Less than a year later: cars repossessed, lost the house, lost everything
    - Brandon's takeaway: "Experience is the best teacher, but it doesn't have to be *your* experience."
- Brandon's personal vow: he now works 12–14 hours/day even when things are great, so he's never again unable to help the people he cares about

💰 Money Lesson 3: Bootstrap First, Investors Later 33:06

- Most aspiring entrepreneurs ask "How do I find investors?" before they've proven anything
    - If you've never run a business and haven't validated your idea in the marketplace, you won't get investors — nor should you
    - "If you ain't never turned $1 into $2, why should I believe you know how to turn $100,000 into a million?"
- Having a good idea ≠ having the skills to execute it
    - Example: "If I had the idea for Uber before it came out, I'd have f***ed that idea up."
- Solution: **come up with an idea you can execute right now with the resources you have**
    - Ideas are free; put guardrails on your ideas based on what you can actually execute
    - Service-based businesses are ideal — low startup cost, no inventory
- Brandon's path: bootstrapped online training → made first million → used that to fund supplement company → had an exit (NDA prevents disclosure of amount)
    - "I didn't have no investors for that. I just bootstrapped that s**t."
    - Regret: probably wouldn't have sold the supplement company if he could do it over — hard to turn down lump sums

💰 Money Lesson 4: Know Your Numbers — Life Is Just Math 37:17

- You must know your business numbers like the back of your hand
    - Key metrics to know: cost to acquire a customer, lifetime value (LTV), revenue over last 90 days, close rate (calls taken vs. assigned), show-up rate
    - Shark Tank analogy: entrepreneurs who don't know their numbers get laughed out — many people run their lives the same way
- **Life is just math** — the rest is noise:
    - To build a profitable business: LTV > cost of acquisition; increase LTV and lower CAC to make more money

    - To lose fat: burn more calories than you consume
    - To get rich: make more than you spend and invest the difference
- Specific example of compound investing:
    - $2,000/month into the S&P 500 index fund
    - S&P 500 average annual return: **10%**
    - Result after 20 years: **$1.3 million**
    - Want to get there faster? Increase monthly investment or find a higher-return vehicle
- Brandon's take on "bro productivity" culture:
    - NoFap, cold plunge, red light therapy, making your bed, affirmations — "bro astrology"
    - None of it matters if the math isn't right; and if the math is right, none of it is necessary
    - "I ain't made my bed in close to a decade."

💰 Money Lesson 5: Squeeze What You Have Before Starting Something New 42:05

- **Shiny object syndrome** is one of the biggest killers of potential success
    - People cycle through: Forex trading → NFTs → crypto → faceless YouTube → Amazon FBA → repeat
    - Never stick with anything long enough to get real traction
- Success is **not linear** — it follows an exponential curve:
    - Early phase: lots of effort, minimal visible progress
    - Eventually: momentum builds and results accelerate beyond expectations
    - Most people quit in the early flat zone — the **"quit zone"** — right before the curve takes off
    - The "baller zone" is on the other side of the quit zone — where people say "I never expected this level of success"
- Progress compounds the longer you stay in something:
    - Brandon has been in fitness for 27 years — trainer → online trainer → supplement company → marketing agency for influencers → coaching trainers
    - All vertical moves within the same domain; never pivoted sideways
- "I know people who make millions doing every single thing you quit — they just went through the quitting zone."
- Before launching something new: there is almost certainly money left in your current offer that you haven't stayed with long enough to extract

💪 Body Lesson 6: You Can't Out-Train a Bad Diet 55:28

- Diet is the cornerstone of body composition — not cardio, not training volume
- The math:
    - 1 lb of fat = 3,500 calories

  - To lose 2 lbs/week → 1,000 calorie/day deficit; to lose 1 lb/week → 500 calorie/day deficit
  - Running 1 mile burns ~100 calories — not even close to meaningful for fat loss on its own
  - A cup of rice has more than 100 calories; a banana wipes out a mile of running
- Cardio is for cardiovascular health — it's literally called "cardio," not "fat loss"
  - Use cardio to push yourself into a *deeper* deficit after diet is dialed in, not as the primary tool
- **Track your calories** — Brandon's non-negotiable:
  - Has tracked calories and macros for 20+ years (notebooks before iPhones, now Claude)
  - "100% of the people I know who track calories and have been doing it for a significant amount of time are in amazing shape. No exceptions."
  - Everyone he knows who looks like trash does not track calories
  - How he tracks: weighs food with a scale he carries everywhere, then logs into Claude with a custom prompt that calculates calories, protein, net carbs, fat, water, and whether he's in a deficit
  - Prompt link available in description
  - Can't use a scale? Take a photo — Claude will estimate. "I believe Claude over you."
- Dismisses influencers who brag about not tracking: "That's not sustainable" sounds like weakness to him
  - "I'm not asking you to do calculus. You ain't even got to add it up. The phone does it."

💪 Body Lesson 7: Eat Your Protein Like It's Your Job 1:06:29

- Recommendation: **1 gram of protein per pound of body weight**
  - This is about more than muscle building — it's about optimizing caloric burn
- **Thermogenic effect of food** (TEF) — calories burned during digestion:

Macronutrient	Calories Burned During Digestion
Fat	1–3% of calories consumed
Carbohydrates	5–15% of calories consumed
Protein	20–30% of calories consumed

- Protein is like a "cashback card" — for every 100 calories of protein consumed, you only absorb 70–80 because digestion burns the rest
  - "It's like a cheat code."
- Brandon's personal sweet spot this summer: ~3,000 calories (maintenance) + **300 grams of protein** (~1.5g per lb of body weight)
  - Describes this as the best shape of his life — but notes this is personal experimentation, not a universal prescription
  - Standard advice he gives clients with 30 years of data behind it: 1g per lb body weight

💪 Body Lesson 8: Stop Drinking Your Calories 1:36:41

- Liquid calories are easy to consume and don't make you feel full — double danger
- Target: **zero liquid calories** (except a plain protein shake if needed)
- Common offenders:
  - Smoothies with peanut butter + banana + whey + milk = "that's not a shake, that's groceries"
  - Soda, juice, sports drinks
- **Fruit juice is a scam:**
  - Juicing removes the fiber (the most important part) and concentrates the sugar
  - What's left: sugar + water + vitamins = effectively Kool-Aid with vitamins
  - A large glass of OJ can be several hundred calories; you'd need to run 2–3 miles to burn it off
  - All sugar — fructose, glucose, sucrose — is processed the same way by the body regardless of source (honey, cane sugar, fruit sugar)
  - Fiber is the only thing that mitigates sugar's negative effects, which is why whole fruit is acceptable but fruit juice is not
- Sugar's broader harms: causes cognitive decline (per studies), causes acne, degrades collagen (ages you faster by breaking down collagen when blood glucose is elevated)
  - Insulin spike and crash explained: blood glucose above 110 → pancreas secretes insulin → indiscriminately removes glucose from body including brain → sugar crash
- If you want antioxidants, eat blueberries or raspberries — far more than honey, without the concentrated sugar

💪 Body Lesson 9: Lift With Form, Not Ego 1:37:22

- Brandon has trained for almost 30 years with no major injuries — attributes this primarily to strict form
- Common ego-lifting mistakes and why they're harmful:
  - Swinging back on bicep curls: uses front delt and hip momentum, removes tension from bicep, raises injury risk
  - Flaring elbows on tricep extensions: skiing-like movement that overloads the wrong structures
  - Arching pelvis on bench press: lifting more than the target muscles can handle
- Correct bicep curl cue: "Act as if your elbow is pinned to your side — only the forearm moves."
- When you're cheating, you're effectively making the weight lighter for the target muscle by recruiting other muscles — so just **drop the weight instead**
  - Drop sets are the correct alternative: hit failure, immediately reduce weight, squeeze out more reps — same effect, safer, better muscle stimulus
- "I don't give a f**k how much I lift. I just know I'm strong." — personal identity not tied to numbers on the bar
- Lift heavy, but only at a weight you can control

💪 Body Lesson 10: Build Your Foundation Now While You're Young 1:41:51

- Muscle built in your 20s creates a lasting foundation — much easier to maintain than to build from scratch later
- "If I had to get in shape in my 40s, that would be so difficult."
- People in great shape in their 40s and 50s almost universally started taking fitness seriously in their 20s
- Your 20s provide maximum testosterone, likely more free time, and physical recovery advantage — squeeze every gain out of that window
- Stay active into your 30s and 40s and the foundation carries forward

🏢 Business Lesson 11: Learn to Sell Before Anything Else 1:43:11

- Brandon's father told him: **"If you learn to sell, you will never go broke."**
- If you're not making sales, you don't have a business — you have a hobby
- Being great at sales covers up almost every other business weakness:
  - Can be bad at Facebook ads, marketing, even product quality — and still succeed if you can sell
  - Brandon credits sales skill for saving his business multiple times during early years when he was bad at other functions
- As a solopreneur you must handle: product/service delivery, customer relationships, marketing, AND sales
  - Most people are weak at several of these — sales is the one you can least afford to be weak at
- Sales should be **the last thing you outsource** — Brandon still personally runs his sales team
- Started selling at 16; learned foundational sales from his father; refined it through years in the gym

🏢 Business Lesson 12: Content Is the Cheapest Form of Lead Generation 1:46:17

- Content creation costs only time and the tools you already have — the distribution is free
- Algorithms across all platforms have democratized reach — follower count matters less now
  - Brandon has seen channels with 2,000–3,000 subscribers get 1M-view videos because the content was good
  - He's also had videos with only 2,000 views due to poor packaging/titles
- The parallel to email: there was a time people resisted getting email; now it's universal and weird not to have it
  - Social media is reaching that same ubiquity — a business without active social media is at a serious disadvantage
- Even paid ads depend on organic social:
  - Many people won't buy directly from an ad — they'll click to your profile, follow, then buy later
  - If your organic social is neglected, paid ads underperform
  - Brandon spends millions in Meta (Instagram/Facebook) and YouTube ads and consistently sees organic sales spike when ads run

🏢 Business Lesson 13: Get Your Ideas Out of Your Head — Build SOPs 1:49:35

- If the business only runs in your head, you have a hustle — not a real business
- **SOPs (Standard Operating Procedures)** for every function:
  - Document exactly how each step of your business is done
  - Enables you to hand off tasks to people or to AI agents
  - Book recommendation: **The E-Myth** by Michael Gerber
- McDonald's example: the reason McDonald's scaled globally is that every task had a written SOP — anyone could be plugged into any role and produce consistent results
- Brandon's process:
  - First hire was a video editor — he had the SOP ready, slid the hire into the role immediately
  - Now that AI does his editing, he gave Claude and ChatGPT the same SOP for how he wants videos done
  - AI agents now run large portions of his business
- Without SOPs: when you eventually hire, new people walk into chaos and nothing scales

🏢 Business Lesson 14: Hire What You Hate (Know Your Hourly Rate) 1:52:38

- Once you know your hourly rate, apply it to every task in your business AND your life
  - If a task can be done by someone else for less than your hourly rate, and you can work during that time, outsourcing it is a **net positive**
- Example — Sebastian with a $100/hour rate:
  - Hires a cleaner on TaskRabbit at $50/hour → works during that time → nets $50 instead of "saving" $50
  - Gets meal prep at ~$200/week → saves ~5 hours of grocery shopping, cooking, and cleaning → works during those 5 hours → nets $300 after the $200 cost
  - Switches to Claude for content editing at $200/month → saves potentially 40 hours/month → saves thousands of dollars in equivalent work time
- Brandon's own early move: first things he stopped doing when making initial traction were cooking, cleaning, and laundry — so he could work during those hours
  - "I wasn't like rich, but this s**t is cheap, man."
- Brandon estimates his Claude Max plan ($200/month) helps generate several hundred thousand dollars extra per month across his businesses
- The framework: **maximize hourly rate → identify everything that can be delegated below your hourly rate → delegate it → fill that time with high-value work**

🏢 Business Lesson 15: Adopt New Tools Early 1:54:47

- Being an early adopter of platforms and tools is not luck — it's **aggressive adaptation**
- Brandon's track record:

- YouTube: early; Facebook video: early (hit 1.5M Facebook fans in about a year); Instagram: early; TikTok: early
- ChatGPT: taught his community how to use it **the week it launched** — even when it was slow and buggy
- Gemini Argon: within 24 hours of launch, had a video showing what he built with it to make money
- Grok ("Muse"): immediately made videos on different ways to make money with it

- "It's not luck. It's aggression. It's aggressive implementation."
- The pace of new tools is accelerating — the cost of being a laggard is rising

🤝 People Lesson 16: Your Standards Drift Toward the People Around You 1:44:28

- You will become like the people around you — involuntarily — whether you want to or not
- **New England Journal of Medicine obesity study** (32-year study, ~12,000 participants):
  - If a friend becomes obese → you have a **57% chance** of becoming obese
  - If your friend's friend (someone you don't even know) becomes obese → you still have a **20% chance** of becoming obese
- Emotions are contagious (negative and positive): one negative person can tank a whole room's vibe; a happy child or friendly dog can light it up
- Beliefs are contagious via the **Reticular Activating System (RAS)**:
  - When you buy a new car, you start seeing that car everywhere — it was always there, you just now notice it
  - If friends constantly complain → your RAS is tuned to find problems
  - Brandon and his circle talk about making money and moves → he sees opportunities everywhere
- Nobody is born with an accent — you pick it up involuntarily from surroundings; same with religion, dress, beliefs
  - "If you were born somewhere else, you'd believe a different god and have different sneakers."
- Choose your circle wisely — it is one of the highest-leverage decisions you will make

🤝 People Lesson 17: Not Everybody Gets to Come With You 2:09:56

- Some friends from your past simply aren't going in the same direction — and that's okay
- Brandon had to leave behind friends who were still chasing parties, drugs, and hoes when he was locked in on building
  - "They gonna call you names and talk s**t about you — until you make it. When you make it, suddenly you were always their boy."
- Leaving people behind is not cruel — it's necessary for growth
- It will feel lonely temporarily; the people you gain on the other side are worth it

🤝 People Lesson 18: Learn to Negotiate 2:10:45

- Book recommendation: **Never Split the Difference** by Chris Voss — Brandon has read it ~50 times
  - Voss is a former FBI hostage negotiator; Brandon vouches for his credibility (humorously references Voss's much-younger girlfriend as proof of his negotiating skills)
- Everything in business involves negotiation: partnerships, vendor deals, pricing, hiring
- Important caveat: **there is a point of diminishing returns with negotiation**
  - You can get so good that you extract everything and leave the other party with insufficient incentive to perform
  - "I had to learn to leave more on the table — it's better to focus on making the pie bigger, not on the size of your slice."

🤝 People Lesson 19: People Buy From People They Like 2:14:52

- Book recommendation: **How to Win Friends and Influence People** — Brandon calls it "the best book ever written" and his all-time number one
- The key to being likable: **be more interested in other people than you are in impressing them**
  - Ask people about themselves — that is the main thing
  - In sales: you should be talking only 20% of the time; the rest should be questions about the prospect
- This applies in dating, business, networking — everywhere

🤝 People Lesson 20: Help Other People Get Results 2:16:26

- Your best marketing is **results you've gotten for other people** — not results you've gotten for yourself
  - "Just because something worked for me doesn't mean it'll work for anyone else — but if I show you hundreds of people it worked for, at some point you have to believe it's legit."
  - Testimonials = Amazon reviews for your business
- Business is fundamentally problem-solving:
  - Road mic → solved the podcast audio problem
  - Apple computer → solved the streaming/AI workload problem
  - Meal prep company → solved the cooking/time problem
  - "If you can solve other people's problems and get them results, it will be super easy for you to make money."

🧠 Mindset Lesson 21: Discipline Is for Amateurs 2:17:27

- Discipline = doing what you're supposed to do even when you don't want to
  - The implied problem: you're *fighting your own brain* — your natural inclinations are against the behavior
  - That is an amateur's approach; pros don't rely on discipline

- David Goggins example from *Can't Hurt Me*: at the starting line of an ultra-marathon he wasn't entered in, he heard the gun and just started running — leaving his girlfriend and friends behind without registering
  - "That is not discipline. He just *wanted* to do it."
- **The solution: change your associations with pain and pleasure using the List of Hate and List of Great**
  - Sigmund Freud's framework: all human behavior is motivated by moving toward pleasure or away from pain
  - Currently, most people associate: pain with working out / diet / studying; pleasure with drugs / junk food / vices
  - Discipline tries to override this — it's fighting nature; instead, *change the associations*
- **List of Hate:**
  - Write down everyone who wronged you, talked s**t, said you couldn't do it, cheated on you
  - Look at it every morning and multiple times daily
  - Frame: every time you slack off, the haters win
- **List of Great:**
  - Write down every attribute of the future version of yourself who accomplished all your goals
  - What time does he wake up? What does he eat? How does he train? How does he treat family?
  - Look at this list every day as well
  - When tempted by vices: "How would the haters feel if I didn't work out right now?"
  - When doing the right thing: you get a dopamine hit from acting in accordance with who you want to become → you get addicted to that feeling
- Over time, with repeated exposure: pain associations flip to vices; pleasure associations flip to work
  - You'll know it's working when you need discipline to *stop working* — not to start
  - Brandon: "My girl wants to go on a trip next month. I'mma need discipline to go on that trip."
- Discipline is an emergency tool — not the plan

🧠 Mindset Lesson 22: Focus Only on What You Can Control 2:28:28

- There is a massive amount of noise in the world — controversies, culture war stuff, other people's choices
- Brandon's filter: "If it doesn't f**k with my family and doesn't f**k with my money, I'm not going to think about it."
- Energy spent on things you can't control is energy stolen from the things you can change
  - "You can't change the whole world. But you can change *your* world if you put enough focus on it."
- Stay ruthlessly focused on your controllables

🧠 Mindset Lesson 23: Think Bigger Than What's Comfortable 2:29:12

- Setting only "realistic" goals based on current ability removes the need to grow

- Setting goals beyond current capability **forces growth**:
  - When Brandon set goals he knew he couldn't accomplish, he asked: "What do I have to learn? Who do I have to become to reach this?"
  - That question drove the self-improvement that got him there
- Think bigger than what feels comfortable — it is the mechanism of growth, not an act of delusion

🧠 Mindset Lesson 24: Write Your Rules Down 2:30:05

- Inspired by **Ray Dalio's Principles**: every mistake Dalio made, he turned into a written rule/principle
  - This compounding of lessons from failure is how he built the **world's largest hedge fund** — after coming close to bankruptcy
- Written rules:
  - Remove the need for in-the-moment decision-making
  - Reduce cognitive load — you just follow the rule
  - Must be based on your own real-life experiences and failures, not someone else's
- Your rules should evolve — they should be a living document of hard-won lessons

🧠 Mindset Lesson 25: Everything Compounds 2:31:39

- People discuss compound interest in money, but the principle applies to everything:
  - Skills: get 1% better every day → at the end of 3 months, you are ~90% better — and it actually compounds, so the real number is higher
  - Being 80–90% as good as LeBron at basketball isn't 80–90% of his success — the success curve is exponential, not linear
  - The longer you compound improvement in one domain, the harder it becomes for others to catch up
- **Bad habits compound too:**
  - Nobody gains 30 lbs overnight — it's a few hundred extra calories a day
  - A few hundred calories over maintenance every day → ~20 lbs of fat in one year
  - Do that for several years → obese
  - The majority of Americans are obese because of compounding small bad decisions

> Every decision counts because everything compounds — for better or worse.

- The call to action for every choice: "Think about every decision in terms of what it compounds into."
- Episode closes with reminder to register for the free live training (link in description) and to apply for the setter position if interested in remote sales